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Jackie Cain & Roy Kral
(Jackie & Roy)

Lovers of American music can boast of no more famous husband and wife duo than Jackie & Roy. Jackie Cain and Roy Kral first worked together in the band of Charlie Ventura in 1948 and were married a year later. They established a recognizable sound with their recordings of "East of Suez" and "Flamingo." Their career has taken them from the clubs of Las Vegas, to the TV studios of Chicago, the stages of jazz festivals and the ad agencies of New York. They have recorded frequently with top jazz artists and a release by Jackie & Roy always delivers the highest level of musicianship. The perfect blend of their voices and the signature sound of Roy's arrangements have made possible a swinging collaboration that recently celebrated its fiftieth anniversary.

Jackie & Roy were interviewed in New York City on March 22, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College.

MR: We are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive today, in New York City. And I am very pleased to have two of America's treasured musicians, Jackie Cain and Roy Kral.

RK: Heeeey. Thank you, Monk.

JC: Good afternoon, Monk.

MR: Good afternoon. I think it's safe to say you're treasured musicians, because I saw the audience reaction last night at Town Hall.

RK: I loved it.

JC: Yeah. You know it was kind of funny because standing backstage when they said that Joe [Williams] wasn't going to appear, because he was ill, and everybody went awww, and I thought oh gee, now we have to jump into his shoes. But then when we came out we got such a wonderful reception.

RK: It was such a warm reception. And I talked to George Wein who was backstage, and I said, "George, it was so wonderful. We walked out, we hadn't done anything, and yet we got this great reception." He says, "well, we'll have to do more of this." So that was very nice.

MR: You remind him of that occasionally.

RK: I will do it.

MR: I think quality always wins out. And I'll give you a belated congratulations on your fiftieth anniversary together as a couple, both in music and in marriage.

RK: Thank you.

JC: Well we've been married 48 years. But we've been working together for 50.

MR: So was it love at first note for you guys?

RK: No. Oh yes, love at first note. But not at first sight.

JC: That's true.

RK: Not at first sight.

JC: Yeah, actually.

RK: She was much too young for me.

JC: Well Roy's seven years old than I am, so at that point when I was about 18, 17, 18 years old—

RK: She told me she was 16.

JC: No. I met him when I was 17 I believe it was. And he had another girlfriend, and I was just this little naive girl from Milwaukee you know. So I don't think I attracted his attention that much. But then he did like working with me I believe.

RK: Here's what happened. A friend of mine brought her in to the club, Jump Town, it was early '47, on the west end of Chicago. Dave Garroway was looking for sponsors. Jump Town was his first sponsor. He talked up the club. He talked it up, talked it up, the place starts to boom. And this friend of mine, a tenor player, brought Jackie in to hear our quartet. I was working with the George Davis Quartet. It was alto, piano, bass and drums. And this tenor player said, "hey let her sing, she's really good." And I says, "naaa, don't be bringing your girls in here, they'll ask me to play in the key of X, something that I don't know anyway."

JC: Piano players never like to play for girl singers, because half the time they don't know what key they sing and they don't know what tune they want to do, and that sort of thing. So they're sort of negative about it in general.

RK: So I said no, no, no deal. We went to the bar and libations, and Vete [Bob Anderson] said, "ah come on, she's good." She'll — okay. She sang "Happiness is Just a Thing Called Joe." And I happened to have loved that song because hearing Frances Wayne sing it with Woody Herman's band, a Neal Hefti arrangement. I said God, that's great. Okay. And she sang that. The club owner was there that night, and he came up to us and said, "you guys need a singer for Friday and Saturday." Okay.

JC: And that's how we started working together. But I was just the girl singer. I mean we didn't do things together in the beginning. I was just singing ballads and uptempos and do a few tunes every set. And the group was quite a good group. And then eventually as we went along, suddenly we heard, let's see Buddy Stewart and Dave Lambert with Gene Krupa. We had heard it around that time. They did some records where they used their voices singing together, with the instruments of the orchestra, and it was vocalese all the way, no lyrics, and we said hey that's great. And we enjoyed it. So then suddenly we said well why don't we try something like that, because Roy really was an arranger and a

composer. So we said let's do something similar to that, in our own way. So he started writing some little arrangements for us, which were generally the tune first, with the lyrics, and then it went into a vocalese part. And we had quite a few in our repertoire, and that's actually when Charlie Ventura heard us, at a Dave Garroway concert.

RK: Dave would present concerts in Chicago. He would have a nationally famous jazz group, and then a local jazz group. And so we came in there ready man. We were loaded for bear — you know — yeah, we can do it. And God we were so young and unknowing. But we had all these vocalese things. And with my alto player, George Davis. So we did these things, and we poured it on hot baby, and the group, it was really good. It was good.

JC: Swinging, yeah.

RK: And three days later, Charlie Ventura and his manager came out to Jump Town and heard us. And then the next day they called and said, "Charlie is forming a new band, would you two like to join?" We said yeah.

MR: You were married at this time?

JC: No, no, no. No we weren't.

MR: Okay. But they definitely wanted the two of you.

JC: They wanted the two of us yeah. Because see he had been traveling at that time with Buddy Stewart and Kai Winding on trombone and Shelly Manne, and Lou Stein on piano, and Bob Carter on bass. And so they had Buddy singing ballads and doing some things with voice-horn things, with Charlie. And I was just the girl singer at first, for a few minutes, because he had a job at the Sherman Hotel and the College Inn and they had airtime and they wanted a girl singer. But you know something funny happened. I just recalled this. That the announcer was not at the club, he was in the studio. The band played for dancing, but we also did some show things and special material. So from the studio the guy one night said, "and now, a vocal by the lovely Kai Winding." They thought Kai Winding was the woman, and my name being Jackie, Jackie Cain, sounded more like the guy. So he kind of got it mixed up.

RK: Well you confuse the issue. This is before we joined forces with Charlie.

JC: Yeah. Well just for that one job. And then Roy was writing the arrangements for me and so then finally he wanted us to work together.

RK: And I wrote, they left the city and I wrote the whole book in three weeks, and it was tenor of course with Charlie, trumpet, baritone and trombone. And wrote the book for this engagement that started at the Blue Note in Chicago. And that was 1948 I believe.

JC: '48, yeah I think so.

RK: And one of the tunes we did last night was from 1948 and the original bebop arrangement of "I'm Forever Blowing Bubbles."

MR: I was going to ask you about that.

RK: Yeah.

MR: That's a lot of writing first of all, in three weeks.

RK: I stayed at the piano and just wrote stuff out. I just stayed there for three weeks. And they came into town and we rehearsed and opened the next day.

JC: And we just had enough to do for a show or two and that was all, and then stretch them out a little bit with the blowing.

MR: At that point did you have an idea of how the voicing worked best with the voice amidst the horns?

RK: Well the thing is, our voices are an octave apart. A perfect octave. We have the same range top to bottom, which makes it easier. You don't have to jump octaves to sing the same song or anything. Now with the horn all we have to do is I have to write the horn in to what we're doing, period.

JC: And a lot of things we did were actually unison but because of the chords that were used and because of our voices being an octave apart, it sounded really like we were almost doing harmony some of the time.

RK: When two instruments play perfect octaves, then in between are all these overtones. And so the two voices, when we sing in tune — once in a while—

JC: And also we did go into harmony too you know. I mean there were sections where we'd go into harmony and some places we did use harmony, and we did counterpuntal stuff too eventually as we went on. We kept experimenting with different things.

RK: You heard us do "Cheerful Little Earful" last night.

MR: Yes.

RK: Now that is — the whole thing is all two lines going counterpuntal, until we get to the ending. And you notice that I didn't use piano until the very end. And what surprised me, and I enjoyed very much, was that after going through all this with just first drums and then the bass, and then just the bass and the drums and the two voices, when the piano finally comes in, the audience went yeahhhh. I said why do they applaud? I think it's because they say gee they're still in the same key.

MR: That's an accomplishment.

JC: And also I think too the fact that we sing the vocalese for two choruses and then when you finally come in with the lyrics, they think wow, that was something you know.

RK: Yeah. It was enjoyable.

MR: Oh yeah. And it built so nice, and when the piano finally comes in, it makes everything that came before it so much better, it really does.

RK: It was a delightful, joyful experience. It just made my evening. You know — yeah.

MR: I wanted to ask about the fade out section on "I'm Forever Blowing Bubbles." I was taking notes while you were playing.

RK: Good. That's called doing your homework.

MR: Yeah. [scats]

[Jackie and Roy scats]

JC: It's easy once you get it.

RK: She would start and then I answer, and it kept alternating.

JC: But originally it wasn't that way. Originally we had a set ending, and it was sort of in harmony with the horn and when we did it with Charlie. But then later on we re-recorded it because I think it was Creed Taylor wanted us to do it again. And we did an album with a big band, you know. It was a great time because we did it with was it—

RK: It was Quincy Jones.

JC: Quincy Jones was the conductor and he did a couple of the arrangements, but we were using it as an arranger's showcase. We had Ernie Wilkins wrote two, Roy wrote two, Quincy wrote two—

RK: Ralph Burns.

JC: Ralph Burns wrote the ballads. And it was really nice.

RK: And Bill Holman did a couple of vocalese things.

JC: Bill Holman did two. And so it was a fun album for us because it got us out of doing the same thing, and you know you like to change what you're doing. It makes it more interesting, more exciting. And so when we did that Ernie Wilkins wrote the arrangement and at the end he changed it. He thought it would be more effective for a record. Because it's easy to do a fade out.

RK: On the board.

JC: On the board you know. But when we started doing it again, we said well let's do it that way. It's kind of a fun ending, but it's hard to do a fade out.

MR: A live fade out.

RK: A live fade out, yeah.

JC: But people get it, especially if you don't use it for your last tune. It doesn't evoke a lot of applause maybe right away.

MR: What made you choose, back then, "I'm Forever Blowing Bubbles?" Or any tune like that, that you wouldn't connect—

RK: It's a funny one. We're doing these things with Charlie Ventura. His manager said, "let's take a song that everybody knows, that everybody's heard all their lives, and do something to it so they know what different treatment we use to do that song." So he says, "how about 'I'm Forever Blowing Bubbles?'"

JC: And we said oh God, no. We thought that's such a corny tune. Even though everybody knows it and it's a fun thing, but I mean—

RK: So he says, "no, try it, see what you can come up with." So I put it in the four-four and that was it.

JC: That was a big record for us.

MR: Do you sit at the piano when you do that? "I'm Forever Blowing Bubbles." Do you sit at the piano and kind of flesh out an idea or do you mostly just think about it?

RK: No. I play it and listen for things. And that's where the, like when we do this vocalese section. That's where the improvisation comes in, where I'm [scats] — and I say oh yeah, yeah. Oh change this a little bit, okay.

JC: You kind of play it over and over and over and go over it until an idea occurs to you, and then you experiment with it.

RK: Because to have it sound right, the two of us have to be exact, and it's like if two tap dancers were to dance together, and they're doing two different things, it would be chop suey. So we have to be precise and do the same things, in fact use the same syllables.

JC: For the most part, but not always, because we go into harmony when we do it, but I mean basically when you do the things together, it's nice.

MR: Did you ever have occasion when you started writing, obviously at some point you had to write the scat down?

JC: Yeah.

RK: At first we did.

MR: Because how do you spell, let's see now [scats]

RK: Just like that.

JC: Yeah. You know the funny thing is we go over it and we try to find the sound that's the closest to what a horn would sound like, where the accents come and things, like if it was a trumpet going dup du ah. So you think dup du ah. You have to sing an open sound.

RK: Or we do, like when we do the thing, du da — du da — du da.

JC: Yeah. You try to duplicate the closest thing you can with the voice.

RK: Like a plunger you know.

JC: But in the beginning we had some pretty funny ones I must admit. Like we did a tune of Roy's called "Euphoria" which was based on the changes of "S'Wonderful." And it was pretty [scats]. I mean we had some [scats] and now it sounds dumb to us. But I remember one time we were working in a club in San Francisco and some guy who was going to college there came up and he was sitting there writing most every night and I thought what the heck is he doing? And he was making a survey on how many times we sang certain vowels and how we were trying — and when he questioned us we said gee I don't know, we don't figure it out to that degree.

RK: I never count how much you sing them. But here's a funny one. We left Ventura at the end of 1949. Then Ruth Price, who runs the Jazz Bakery out in Los Angeles and is doing

very well with it, is also a singer. She joined Ventura after we left, and she said that he had her write down all the syllables on long butcher paper, just sheets of it. And she said she would have it hanging on the walls anywhere she could see it so she could do these charts the same way. And I said, "Oh Ruth, that's terrible to have to do that. Why don't you just make up your own?" She says, "no, he wanted just like it was on the original.

JC: And she probably wasn't used to doing that at that point you know, because she wasn't singing vocalese. And we'd been doing it. Now it's easy. Now when we do just an arrangement we sit down and the right thing sort of comes. Once in a while we'll quibble over you know, we each have a different viewpoint, but then it always comes down to which one works best. But we sort of more or less sing it and fall right into it now. So it's easier.

MR: And you had a couple of really good records in those years with Ventura?

RK: Yeah we had "East of Suez," we had "Euphoria," "I'm Forever Blowing Bubbles," and then after we left Ventura we got into having a mini-hit with "Mountain Greenery," and that was kind of wonderful.

MR: What does a hit in the jazz world translate to in record sales?

RK: Possibly in the top ten of the jazz choices for the week. I think you can only find it in *DownBeat* magazine.

JC: And as far as sales go, I don't think we know anything about that, we'd have to ask Creed Taylor or somebody.

MR: Right, right.

JC: But we've been very fortunate we feel because we've had an opportunity to do different albums with little different flavors to them. Like one time we did an album with about a 14 piece band, that was called "Free and Easy," and that was a great thing. It was all Bill Holman charts, and that was different from the big band album that we did which was about 18 pieces, which had, it was an all-star band. I mean it had Clark Terry, Art Farmer, Phil Woods — no I don't know if it was Phil.

RK: Sure.

JC: But, yeah I think it was. Gene Quill, all these great, great players that we were so honored to be able to work with, and just even having Quincy write and all these people that wrote for it, it was a thrill for us to be able to do that. Because that's what it's all about you know, about doing something new. And people sort of like one thing that they've heard and they get attached to it, and they want you to do it all the time. You know like we don't do "I'm Forever Blowing Bubbles" anymore really, and we don't do "Mountain Greenery," except that this year being our fiftieth anniversary we decided it was a smart thing to do it, and we were not sick of it anymore. I mean when you do it again after you haven't done it after a number of years—

MR: It's okay to revisit it.

JC: Yeah. It's fresher.

RK: Well there's another thing to it. On "Mountain Greenery" we discovered that, well I for one, I can't sing that high anymore.

JC: Yeah it gets harder.

RK: My embouchure is shot.

JC: Well it's harder for him too because he's playing and singing you know, and it's harder to do it. I can make it but some of them are a strain, you know, some of the high notes. But we did put "Cheerful Little Earful" down a half — a half or a whole step.

RK: Huh?

JC: Anyway it doesn't matter. But we made it a little lower because we couldn't sing it that high anymore.

MR: Well at least you don't do it — or you can't — but some of the rock 'n roll guys tune their guitars down a half step so that they can.

RK: Oh yeah, that's true.

MR: Tell the piano player, look could you go tune that thing again. Did you have some association with Studs Turkel?

RK: A dear, sweet friend of ours and a friend of jazz.

JC: Actually, I was the first one to work with him with Charlie Ventura when we did that Sherman Hotel College Union thing, because he was the emcee. Dave Garroway was the emcee for some of the shows, and he alternated when Dave couldn't make it. And so that's when we first met him. You met him then too. And then later on we've done a lot of interviews with him.

RK: Went up to his studios and did interviews and talked and he would play the current records and so forth. And he would always come in to a club to see us. And let's see, two years ago, when we did Jazz Nativity at Orchestra Hall in Chicago, Studs took the place of Charles Kuralt and introduced the show. Now for Christmas, Studs came in, came first to see us, his dear friends, we sat in the room and we just talked about old times and this and that. And he was wearing this old raincoat and a great big red scarf around his neck.

JC: A muffler.

RK: A muffler, and this crunched hat. And I said, "well Studs, you're going to host the show, what are you wearing?" He says, "this is what I'm wearing. I want to look like a caroler."

JC: And he was wonderful.

RK: And he did.

JC: He walked out on that stage and the whole audience erupted into applause. It was great. And he's such a — I really love that guy. He's so vital and I mean I don't know how old he is—

RK: He's over 80, I'm sure.

JC: He's in his eighties somewhere. And he's just so full of life and inspiration, and he's a very dynamite guy.

RK: He's very animated.

JC: And a great writer, great writer, and he's interested in everything. He's interested in people, and of course he loved Alec Wilder so the minute we see him we talk about Alec Wilder and all the friends of ours that we have that are mutual friends. Fun.

MR: Tell me about "East of Suez" and how that was conceived. Is the arrangement that you did on—

JC: On the "East of Suez" album?

RK: This is a new arrangement of "East of Suez." Because the original was not in our key, it was something that Charlie had down and that's the way he kept it. And we were out of our range, we'd have to keep jumping octaves and stuff. So Jeff from Concord, Jeff the owner—

JC: Oh, I can't think of his name right now, yeah.

RK: I can't remember. He heard us do it at a concert.

JC: Carl Jefferson.

RK: Carl Jefferson. He said, "you've got to do that song as part of a new CD you're going to do for me, a new album you're going to do for me."

JC: He loved it, he loved it.

RK: And so we did, but I had to change the key and do the whole thing over. And different instrumentation.

JC: That was actually a Lou Stein tune that he had written for Charlie and Charlie did it with Buddy Stewart and Kai Winding. And it was recorded that way the first time, but then when we joined the band he wanted us to do it naturally, because it was a good record for him, a big record. So that's how we started doing it. But we love it. I think it's a great piece.

MR: This particular arrangement reminds me of like how I usually hear "Green Dolphin Street" with the Latin and swing, back and forth. It's a nice exchange.

JC: Yeah. That's another popular jazz, people always ask for that. We've never done it, but maybe one of these days.

MR: Well after you left Ventura then did you decide to lead your own ensembles?

RK: We did.

JC: And that's when we got married.

RK: We wanted to — yeah we got married, that was pretty important, it was very nice. And we decided that we wanted to do something different because we didn't want to go right back with tenor and the horns and everything. So I started a group with amplified cello

and guitar. Guitar would play tremulo to make sustained notes, and the bass would play arco. So those three, the cello and the bass and guitar, and the voices. Now that's five lines, drums and piano. And it worked beautifully. And it was a wonderful sound, but no one was ready for it. So we had it about a year and a half and it was just like putting money into it, putting money into it, and—

JC: I think part of the reason too is the fact that we started it and we weren't that famous yet. I mean we had gotten a certain amount of notoriety with Charlie with the records, and we had a certain following, but we weren't that well known. And when we first started with this group, we were working around Chicago and sort of in that area, and we were working strange clubs where people probably never heard of us, and saying what is this? And it was so unusual to see a cello playing jazz, and we had a girl who could improvise a little bit, and it was very interesting. The sound was wonderful, and we had fun doing it. We were the first ones to ever use the cello in a jazz group I believe.

RK: Let's see — who else used it after that? Chico Hamilton, right?

JC: Yeah, Chico and there have been other people since, but I think it's a great sound.

MR: I'm curious, did you listen to a lot of Bach and Vivaldi as a child?

RK: Um hum, yes. All through my life, Vivaldi is, and Bach, our favorite music. Because we listen to mostly classical music, and jazz. And not all jazz, and not all classical, but a bit of each. We also are totally enamored of the bossa nova that came in the 60's, and we've been down to Brazil, and they don't do that anymore.

JC: Well they do it but rarely, you'd have to search for it. Now it used to be all over. The first time we went down there was in the 60's, and boy you could just go to so many different clubs and hear the greatest music. But then when we went back a few years ago we went back and we worked down in São Paolo, and we were down there for a couple of weeks and it was hard to find good bossa nova. I'm sure it's there, it's like jazz.

MR: You were in Brazil here.

JC: Exactly.

RK: Brazil now sounds like America in the tropics. You know that's it.

JC: Well everything is so generic all over the world now. You know you hear the same kind of — well I won't say how I feel about it. But there's some good music that you hear, but not enough.

RK: Who did we hear on the awards, the western singer?

JC: Oh yeah, oh God.

RK: I remembered his name because I was so struck by this wonderful music. Great harmony. Great players.

JC: I think Gill was his last name, I'm not sure.

MR: His last name was Gill?

JC: Maybe, yeah. Well anyway.

RK: That's as much as I can remember, but anyways it was excellent. It was just wow.

JC: There are some good people in country music now.

MR: Oh Vince Gill.

JC: Vince Gill.

RK: Vince Gill, yes.

JC: Vince Gill and then that new young girl, Leann Rimes? She's a fabulous singer, got a great voice and she's just true blue, you know right in there. It's the kind of stuff you like to hear.

MR: Well it's curious you say that things are becoming too generic. I mean world music is now a category you can go to the record stores and see world music. I guess I had a question there I'm not sure what it was. Except that—

RK: I've got the answer if you can think of the question.

MR: Okay I'll try. There's so much recording going on and everybody's hearing everything from everywhere else, maybe it tends to dilute it some by the time everybody hears it and puts out their own version of it.

JC: Yeah. Well just like all the traditional things from different parts of the world, you know, as far as dress goes or customs, I mean it's all getting lost. I mean even in India they don't make the beautiful cloth and fabric that they used to make. I mean they invented paisley and all these beautiful things and now they're wearing, you see guys with baseball hats and jeans. The young people are into that, which is kind of sad. It's just like losing the culture of the American Indians. How many people make rugs, Indian rugs, anymore? It's a dying art. And music is the same. But some people try and keep it alive.

RK: However, I believe that this music we're involved with will live forever, and eventually there'll be a huge resurgence of interest in it. Because everyone is eventually going to get tired of loud and too basic. We notice that already.

JC: Well as they say, from your voice to God's ears. You know they say that because it would be nice if more people — but you know with all the college programs and things that are happening concerning learning jazz and studying it and everything, I think that's going to help it a lot. Although you know in the old days you learned on your own by going out and doing it. And that's really key also. Once you know something about it and you're good at it, you have to get out there and practice it in front of an audience and develop your own style and so forth.

RK: Let me see there's North Texas State, which is kind of wonderful, Berklee, and —

JC: William Paterson.

RK: William Paterson, near us, excellent. And you guys up there at your school.

MR: There's Eastman School of Music also. There's lots of — but so many people say that, veteran musicians, that you have to get out there and do it and play with lots of different people and I suppose someday someone may be able to come up with a program where you're in college but you do a semester out in the clubs somehow.

RK: Well you'd have to be a good player to get into the clubs and be allowed to sit in, because there's so many good players now that it's unbelievable. It's wonderful. So there is a great future for this music.

JC: Just like when you go to Japan you know, you hear players over there that are fantastic, they're just ridiculous. But there's one thing missing sometimes, and that's a certain swing and a certain feeling that they don't get. It sounds very — how can I express it — it's just mechanical in a way. But I mean their technique just overwhelms you. My God they're so wonderful. But there's sometimes little things missing.

RK: In jazz.

JC: In jazz. That's what I meant, right.

MR: So after the kind of short lived group with the cello, did you consciously sit and say okay the public wasn't quite ready for that, what are we going to do now.

RK: What we did was —

JC: Have a baby.

RK: Yeah.

JC: In the interim, amidst all these things, we're having kids, and having to deal with—

MR: Real life things.

JC: Having to do with just living in your life and you know, because and that's been probably one of our problems in the sense of being known to the public, because every time we'd get a little momentum going, as far as having people know us more widely, we would have a family thing happen. It was wonderful. We were happy about it.

RK: And it was — I was going to say what we did was cut down to just the two of us, just piano and the two voices, and we worked anywhere we could. Because things were rather slow. See a lot of clubs were closing, and we worked anywhere we could. And finally we got on the road with a child, and we had a station wagon with a rack on the top, and we had a kind of a buggy, and behind the back seat—

JC: One of those that you lift out of the frame you know? And you put it behind the second seat in the station wagon and so if you have to change the baby you get on your knees and you've got your own little bassinet right there. And that was the days when you had to sterilize bottles and everything. Every night you'd check into a motel on a trip you know, and have to take the sterilizer in and wash the bottles and sterilize them. And luckily she was, by that time, just drinking milk rather than formula. And so I just had to fill the bottles. But still it was like ohh.

MR: This is reality.

JC: This is reality, but thinking back on it, it was fun. It was like having to deal with it and we were young enough and had the energy and the will to do it.

MR: What would happen if you have a duo gig, and you're on the road in your station wagon, what did you do with your child while you were performing?

RK: Well we went to Hawaii, and we were working at this hotel on the roof, and we got into there and didn't know who we were going get, and finally we found a young Japanese girl who was very responsible, and we would get ready for work and she would come in and read to our first daughter, and then put her to bed, and this Japanese girl would go into the bathroom with the lights on, and do her reading and do her homework, and take care that we finish our show, and we'd come in and she'd go home.

JC: We had to find people wherever we were and it was always very nerve wracking because you know, are we going to find somebody for the first night? And in fact, in that incident, in Hawaii, we didn't have anyone for the first night, but luckily it was in the same hotel, and so we got her to sleep and we went upstairs and did our show, but this is what happened. She heard us. She woke up and she heard us because it was all open, there was no air conditioning, it was like an open roof thing, and it was just screened in. And in fact I don't even know if it was screened in. But anyway she heard us and she went out of the room in her little Dr. Denton's and she went looking for us, and ended up down in the lobby and the people in the lobby said well where are your parents, little girl? And she said well I hear them singing. And so somebody took over. But that was — the only reason she could get out is because the door was one of those that you lock with a little button on the inside, and so she could open it from the inside but you couldn't get in from the outside. So anyway that was one of the funny incidents. And a lot of stuff like that happened. But most of the time we were very good, I mean we were lucky we found people the first day we got there through somebody in the club who knew somebody or whatever it was. And then eventually when we had our second child, we started carrying a live-in woman, a mother's au pair, like a mother's helper. And that was good because we had somebody steady then who went with us. Well we couldn't that until we made a little more money so we could afford to pay her. But we were lucky in that sense.

MR: When was your next chance to record, at this point? I'm sorry, this was around mid-50's?

JC: The first one was '52.

RK: First child in '52, so we played and performed everywhere.

JC: I think that's when we did the last big band.

RK: Yes and no.

JC: Oh okay.

RK: Then at one point Charlie Ventura called us again and said, "listen, I have a club in New Jersey, I would like to have the original group, put it back together, would you guys care to join us?" Now we had an apartment in Chicago, and I had been playing solo piano at a little joint, just to make a living, while our first child was growing. And so we said hey this is a good way, because I'd been doing that for about a year and a half, different places around Chicago, playing for acts, doing this, writing, playing for singers, and —

JC: It sounded like a perfect opportunity.

RK: We said great, yes, we'll do that.

JC: Because we could also move there. He had his own club, it was called Charlie's — what was it called? Open House. And it was on the White Horse Pike outside of Philadelphia, and so it was sort of a semi-permanent thing. We worked there every weekend and he would bring in a comedian from New York City and put on a show and it was a big sort of a white elephant club out on the highway. It was a great place. It had a great stage and a great dance floor, so it was a fun place people came out to. He did very well there for a while. I think he had it for a few years. So we went back there and worked with him. And we got an apartment there, and we subleased something, didn't we? Or just leased something I should say. I think we had a two or three year lease in an apartment there. So we stayed there for a while with him and that was good.

RK: And during that time our friend Alec Wilder entered the scene. We met him through a friend. We were working in New York City. And this friend of ours, who is Rogers Brackett, who is in advertising, said, "listen, I'd like Alec Wilder to hear you, because you're doing some wonderful things now." And he said, "could you come to this apartment, it's on Central Park South?" Okay, sure. So we walk in and here's this sumptuous apartment overlooking Central Park, and here's a little piano over there and pictures on it and everything, and Alec is there and we meet him, and we talked and finally he said well do a couple of things. Alec sat down in a sofa with his back to us. Now I see how smart that was, he didn't have to register anything. And we did this one song, we did "Lover." It starts in three-four and then it goes [scats], and just piano, just piano, Jackie and I. And we did, we finished it, a great big ending and yeah, and all we hear from Alec is like, "oh, no."

JC: Oh, no, oh, no. Which was his sign of approval.

RK: It's like saying "oh, wow." So then we understood — oh yes — okay, he was the first guy that said you're bad.

JC: Yeah. And he had a way of always remarking, like if you'd start something or do something that caught his ear, he'd go, "oh no, no" or something like that. It was weird. It was kind of strange but it was wonderful once we understood.

RK: And we were sitting at the piano and starting to relax a little bit, and we did about six, seven songs, and I keep looking at this picture in front of me on the piano. And I look and look, and it's Winston Churchill and his wife, and someone standing behind them — his daughter Sarah. So we were in Sarah Churchill's apartment, because Alec Wilder knew her and Rogers Brackett knew her, and we could use the apartment to meet Alec while she was out of town. I said, wow, seeing Winston Churchill and Alec at the same day, woooh.

MR: Yeah, pretty cool.

JC: Yeah, that was exciting.

RK: Alec, after that, got us an audition at the Blue Angel in New York City which was run by Max Gordon who eventually owned the Village Vanguard, and the guy's name was Jacoby.

JC: Herb Jacoby.

RK: Herb Jacoby. We used to call him the East Side General DeGaulle.

JC: Because he looked like that.

RK: And he was pompous and well—

JC: He just had that attitude, he just had that kind of, you know, attitude.

RK: So we auditioned, we made it, and we were put into the showroom in the back. Bart Howard was playing piano and playing all those wonderful songs of his, and there were — people would come through like Orson Bean doing his comedy act, Andy Griffith doing his comedy act.

JC: Before anyone knew him.

MR: Oh I didn't know that.

JC: This was before anybody knew him, yeah.

MR: He was a stand-up?

JC: Yeah. He did a stand-up doing Shakespeare and classic stories with a sort of a southern drawl and funny angles to it. It was very good, yeah. Anyway that was—

RK: And there were several other people. And out in the bar, after the show would be over, we would do our thing and then somebody else would do this, or comedy, whatever, a lot of things were happening. Out in the bar this wonderful, exciting piano player, Bobby Short.

JC: Honey, I have to correct you. That isn't true.

RK: Well I wish you hadn't said that.

JC: No, I know. No actually he was out there, but not when we were working there. We went there to see him once.

RK: Well you spoiled a good story but that's okay.

JC: Well he doesn't like to let the truth get in the way of a good story. But you're busted.

RK: Yeah, you wait.

MR: It wasn't Bobby Short?

RK: No it was Bobby Short.

JC: Yeah we went to hear him there another time, and he's confusing it. He thinks it was when we were there but we weren't.

MR: Well then you owe her one.

RK: No, absolutely not.

JC: He's telling the truth, but you see at this time a lot of the jazz clubs were drying up, like 52nd Street wasn't happening anymore, and there weren't that many clubs. A lot of clubs were closing, and we were thinking what were we going to do next you know. And so when the opportunity came along for us to do this audition, we thought hey that's great, that's how we started to getting in to some cabaret, you know what they called cabaret. At that time it was just a joint, it was a saloon you know. But now it's cabaret. And that was an elegant place and they had very good performers all the time. Just hearing all these great comedians in there, they were very funny and we enjoyed the other people working there as well as Bart Howard, and so it was a good opportunity for us. We were there about a month. And I don't remember what happened quite after that. Do you?

RK: We cleared out our apartment in Hollis, New Jersey, outside of Philadelphia—

JC: That's right.

RK: And you—

JC: Got an apartment in Hollis.

RK: No. You were pregnant. We cleared that apartment out and left for Milwaukee. And just before we left for Milwaukee we did "The Tonight Show" with Johnny Carson. And we drove, with all our junk to Milwaukee and my sister helped us pack and everything. You went ahead with Niki, and we got to Milwaukee and Jackie's dad had an IGA supermarket. And one day he was short of help. And he said, "listen, one of my guys didn't show up and a whole bunch of stock came in, could you help me out?" I said sure. So here I am loading coffee cans. Bring the coffee cans in and you stamp them with the price on the top you know, then you take the old ones from the back, put them front, put the new ones in the back and like put them up and I'm doing all this stuff. And a woman comes by and she wheels her cart by me and she stops. And I look and I'm still doing it. She wheels the cart, backs up, and she said, "weren't you on 'The Tonight Show' about three days ago?" And I said yes I was. Putting those cans dum dum dum dum dum.

JC: My parents had a house at that time. Yeah it was funny. My parents had a house at that time, that was a flat. And our lease was up in Hollis, which was on Long Island. We had moved from Philly to Long Island. And so when the lease was up, I was talking to my mother one night on the phone, and I was pregnant at the time, and I said gee we don't

know quite what we want to do now. And she said well why don't you come up here. Well I'd never lived near my mother since I'd left home when I was 17. And we got along fine, so she says you can have the apartment upstairs and you can decorate it any way you want and you can pick out the colors and we're just re-doing it you know. So I said hey that sounds like the answer to our prayers more or less, because we didn't know what we were going to do.

RK: It was angelic guidance, which we've had throughout our lives.

JC: Yeah. Fateful. One of those fateful things. So we went up there, and then stayed until our second child was born. Then we went on the road with her when she was only about six months old. So that's when we — I don't know where we went then, I guess out to California or something.

RK: We were up in Hull, Canada, I remember that was one of the first jobs.

JC: Yeah.

RK: And after that we just — everywhere, Detroit, and up to St. Paul, Minneapolis, out to California, we were there for a long time. And out in California we were doing once again just piano and the two voices. And we were working in a place called John Walsh's 88 Club?

JC: 881.

RK: 881 Club. On LaCienega Blvd. And word got around and all of a sudden Mitzi Gaynor's coming in, Cary Grant is coming in, Ray Milland is coming in, and everybody is coming in and we're doing great business and it was wonderful.

JC: Julie London.

RK: Yeah, Julie London.

JC: And Bobby Troup. You know a lot of people who liked music started coming in there.

RK: And that was good for a while. And pretty soon we started getting different bookings, and we'd get ourselves a group, a rhythm section, and yeah, we're on the road.

JC: On the road again. But I think the next major thing that happened was then we went to Vegas to visit a friend of ours who lived there. And we were on our way to Chicago to work at Mr. Kelly's in Chicago. And so we had the kids in the car and everything, and we went to Las Vegas to visit this friend, and we saw him, we stayed a few days, and one day we bumped into this guy on the street, who used to be Charlie Ventura's manager, Don Palmer. And Don Palmer says, "what are you doing here?" And we said we're just on our way to Chicago, we stopped to see a friend. Well, he says, "listen, this is funny but you know there's a group that was supposed to open at the Thunderbird and they were in an automobile accident and they can't open tomorrow night, so could you open?" And we said, "we don't have a group here or anything, no, we're on our way to Chicago." He says, "well if you could do this for me, it might be very good for you guys, because

maybe you'll get something through them hearing you, you know, maybe you'll get a contract to come back or something." So we said well— he sai, "I'll get you a bass player and drummer."

RK: I'll get you your rhythm section.

JC: He say, "we'll get a rhythm section, you'll rehearse one time or you'll get together tomorrow and open tomorrow night." And we said well okay. We had to arrange with the kids, I don't remember even what we did.

RK: We found an apartment somewhere, just bang, get in there, get in there, rehearse, open up at the Thunderbird.

JC: A rented apartment, furnished you know.

RK: And we were there for two weeks, and it created a stir because we were doing something totally different than the usual front line, who learns how to do dance steps. And we were playing what we do. And I think at one time we had Carl Fontana join us on trombone, and we had a great group. And after the two weeks we had to go to Mr. Kelly's to do our contracted job there. And I told the manager, I said we have to leave to go Mr. Kelly's and do our two weeks over there. And he says you can't leave.

JC: You can't leave.

RK: I said well wait a minute. I said I didn't have a contract with you, we're here, we're doing a job for you, we have a contract with Mr. Kelly's. I said I believe in honoring the contract. After two weeks he says, you go do two weeks and you're back here. I said why not. It was wonderful. So we came back and we stayed a year. Now by this time we bought a house, we rented one and then we bought a different house, and got the kids in school.

JC: That was our first house.

RK: They were starting to be school age. And the school system was wonderful. It was a great school system.

JC: And it was really nice living there too, because even though it was Las Vegas, it wasn't like it is now, it was just like a little sleepy town except for the Strip. The Strip had all the big casinos and everything, and that was kind of bright and wonderful and a lot of great people were coming into the showroom, and so eventually we worked the Thunderbird, and we just started working the gambling circuit because we could have the kids in school, we could be there all the time, and it was another answer to our needs at the time.

RK: In the summer we would take them on the road with us again. We'd go to Reno, go to Lake Tahoe, then make a swing through San Francisco and go down to L.A. and back to Las Vegas, and this time go into The Sands for a year, opposite the Red Norvo Quintet. And that was wonderful, because here we had a good group, a tight group, and Red had a

fantastic group. So we were there for a year and we got to meet everybody who came through The Sands. Now that's Sinatra, Nat King Cole, Jerry Lewis, on and on and on.

JC: Sammy Davis.

RK: Sammy Davis.

JC: Lena Horne.

RK: Also we attracted all the musicians from the Strip to hear these two groups. So the place was booming. It was wonderful.

JC: It was kind of like going to school. You know you'd go into the — because they'd let you go in the showroom in the back of the room and watch everybody that was there. And that was the most musical, that was the most musical place because most of the places didn't have very good music, it was all kind of loud, bashey bands. So the only other thing that was happening was Louie Prima was down at the — what was that The Sahara?

RK: The Sahara.

JC: The Sahara, with —

RK: Keely Smith.

JC: Keely Smith and Sam Butera and the Witnesses. And that was the most musical thing there, until we came along.

RK: Keely was a good singer. She still is.

JC: She was good, yeah, and they had an act that made it for Vegas, you know, with all the deadpan and the takes back and forth and the theatricality of that. But we were just doing music. We were just doing good things. And Red Norvo's group was wonderful, and of course all the guys in the showroom would always come in, like Frank would come in and Nat Cole would come in, and they'd sit in the back at a table and listen to the groups, because it was something they could enjoy.

RK: Or Sinatra would have all the tables lined up right in front of the bandstand in one big long table, like out to the end. And he would invite all these people in to sit all the way around.

JC: Not every night, but sometimes.

RK: Yeah. Occasionally. And I remember this one night, the place is packed. And he calls the head waiter over and he says, "who's that guy down at the end?"

JC: Someone was there that he didn't know.

RK: Tell him his membership is up. And the head waiter went down and talked to the guy and he came back to Frank and he says, "no, he's all right. That's Joe DiMaggio's shirt maker." And Frank says, "okay."

JC: That was funny you know, because he was a friend of his so he couldn't throw his shirt maker out. That's a true story.

MR: Did the advent of rock 'n roll in the late 50s and early 60s affect what you did and how much you were able to do it?

RK: It didn't make too much of a dent because we still had the same clubs that we were working, and we could do repeats up in Buffalo, up in Toronto, Detroit, Baker's Keyboard Lounge up there—

JC: Except in one respect and that was recording. Because at that time we had a manager, what was his name — Monty Kaye was our manager. And Monty Kaye wanted us to incorporate some current music, like Beatles and stuff. Our daughters loved the Beatles and they listened to it, and when we first heard them we didn't care for it much. As they went on they got better, and suddenly the tunes started coming through, the songs became better.

RK: After a year and a half there was some great music that the Beatles wrote.

JC: Yeah. And so we started listening a little more and we said well maybe. And then we picked out a bunch of things and did an album called — what was it called? I can't think of the name of it now.

RK: "Changes." No, was that it?

JC: Yeah, "Changes" was I think the first one we did. And that was, we did a Phil Ochs' tune, we did, what was the other guy, Donovan, and we did some Beatles things, some Lennon-McCartney tunes. And actually it was quite good. A lot of people still love that album. I mean I've had people tell me that they enjoyed it, especially younger people. And then the next one we did right after that was a thing called "Grass" and that was one that also had an electric piano, Roy played electric piano for a while because we thought it would be fun to try it.

RK: Well one of the reasons I changed was that some of the clubs we were working had these terrible pianos. Like they have a baby grand, it's five feet long, and it sounds like it's strung with rubber bands, and there's no music in it. You hit a note and it goes duh, instead of ding. So I said well the only thing I can do, I'll get an electric piano, I'll carry my own, it'll be dependable, it'll be in tune, I'll have the same instrument to play on. So we did that. We had also a bunch of sound equipment.

MR: That part, that gets a lot of fun, doesn't it.

JC: It was fun, and we really enjoyed it for a couple of years, but then all of a sudden it got to be a big chore. Because we did not have somebody to come and set the stuff up.

RK: The drummer and I did all the schlepping.

MR: Did you have a Fender Rhodes or a Wurlitzer?

RK: No I had a Wurlitzer that I had re-worked, where you could plug it directly into an amplifier with a volume foot pedal, and a sustain pedal on it. So it was really a wonderful piano.

JC: And that was closest to an acoustic I think at the time.

RK: And the drummer and I would just take all this equipment, we had great big column speakers and we'd put them in cases lined with foam and up on top of this big monster Chrysler station wagon we had, and lash it all down and cover it with canvas, and, next gig, yo!

JC: I mean you know, that's why he had trouble with his back for a while. But that got to be very difficult. And so finally we just, and then we started working better clubs.

RK: The hardest part was the miles of cable to collect after the gig.

JC: Yeah. That's the hardest part.

MR: Especially when people spill beer on them.

JC: Yeah, oh please. But we finally gave that up because we started working better clubs too. As we were going along nicer clubs started opening that were bringing in music, so we felt that the pianos got better at the same time, and they weren't such a problem. So Roy was happy to get that.

RK: Besides, I started to miss the real piano sound.

JC: Yeah. Nothing like it.

MR: Nothing like it after you go away from it and you say, after a while, this little thing.

JC: So the other thing was cute and funny for a hot minute. But it was a hot two years, but I mean it was fun. Back to the acoustic and that was great, we enjoyed going back.

RK: And then the bossa nova came in hot and heavy and we left Las Vegas in 1961. We were there four years, bought a house, the whole thing. Sold the house in 1962 to the people we were renting it to, but we drove from Las Vegas with our little trailer behind the station wagon, with mops and brooms and buckets and kitchen stuff, and all of our Indian rugs, and just loaded up this trailer.

JC: And left everything else in the house.

RK: Left everything there, all the furniture.

JC: And the kids, don't forget the kids.

RK: Oh yeah.

MR: Do we have them?

RK: Oh yeah, count 'em. And we drove to New York and stopped at a friend's place, Don Payne, a bass player who worked with us and recorded with us, and we found a place to stay. We get into New York but the only place we could find somewhere was a motel and so in September, putting the kids in school in Riverdale, NY, and we're making sandwiches in the motel for the kids, and taking them to school and then bringing them back, and looking for an apartment. Finally we looked and looked and looked and looked and nothing appealed to us because everything was like — here's another cell in the beehive, on the 16th floor of this one. Here's this apartment. I didn't like any of them. I

saw an ad in the paper that said: old house, 5 acres of grounds, private drive, view of the river, and Jackie said, "let's go look at it." I said, oh, you know, "it's going to be an arm and a leg."

JC: Forget it. The funny thing was on the way to New York I had said to Roy gee wouldn't it be great if we could find an old house to live in, because we'd been living in this cement block kingdom in Vegas you know.

RK: And I said to Jackie, that's impossible. Angelic guidance took us to this place and so finally she talked me into looking at it. She says well let's just look at it. So here we look at this house, there's a driveway, it's in a wonderful, private section called Alderbrook, with stone pillars to enter. I says oh this is going to be like four thousand dollars a month or something.

JC: Right off the Henry Hudson River.

RK: And you could look down and see the boats going by and it was right next to Dodge estate, and we found later that Robert Morgenthal, who is now State's Attorney, lived right next door.

JC: And just as important, the house used to belong to Elie Nadelman who is a very famous sculptor, and he's in all the collections, you know, the Museum of Modern Art and the Rockefeller Collection.

RK: Anyway we looked at it. And it was an 1880's, 1865 house. Old. Real Victorian, all the doo dads up on the roof and everything. We looked at the place and there were about one, two, three, maybe five, six rooms.

JC: This was just part of the house. It was a 21 room house. But there was a caretaker living in the main part of the house, and this part was being rented out.

RK: Either it was guest quarters or servant's quarters originally. Well we looked at it and there was wonderful things like a gas fireplace in the living room, a real fireplace in the bedroom, and we said gee this is wonderful, how much? Three hundred dollars a month. And at the time — wait a minute — at the time I wasn't paying that much of a mortgage on the house, and I said oh that's much too much, that's ridiculous. And the bass player, who was with us, nudged me and he said, "if you don't take it, I'm going to take it."

JC: Yeah. We were worried about the heat you know, like is it going to be heated, it's such an old house. Is the plumbing going to work? That kind of thing.

RK: So we had to wait ten days while the legal part of it, the lawyers had to check us out, check our kids out, go back through our backgrounds to give us the okay. And finally we got the okay and we moved in. We stayed there 11 years. And it was wonderful because up on the third floor, which we finally gained access to, were some of these Nadelman marble busts. We held them in our hands and looked at them. Wooden, marble, everything.

JC: And there were big sculptures on the property too that were part of the art.

RK: The front gate is of a huge dog, this high, one on each side, and you walk through them and that's the entrance to the grounds. There was a 350-year-old copper beech tree on the grounds, and up the hill was the Dodge estate, and that became, in the winter, a sledding hill, and it was a dangerous hill, because our drummer, who had been a paratrooper, he and I went sledding. And we'd go down this hill and you'd make a turn here go up around this one and go along this path, and he went over the path and he fell down over nine feet onto a driveway, and he said, "oh, it was just like a parachute jump."

JC: It was like heaven though, you know, because it was great for the kids, it was a great neighborhood for them to be in, and we just really enjoyed it for eleven years. Oh and all the Brazilians came there too because every time, at that time, when anybody was coming to New York from Brazil, all the musicians, they would come to our friend Don Payne's house.

RK: Because he had been in Brazil with Tony Bennett.

JC: And they'd come to his house and he'd bring them over to our house, and we had several sessions with them playing in our dining room. And we met Antonio Carlos Jobim, we met Joao Gilberto, we met Carlos Lyra, Edu Lobo, and Astrud was married to Joao at the time, and they came over with their little child, and I mean we met all these people, it was great, just wonderful.

MR: Boy you have had some angelic guidance along the way.

JC: Well it seems that way, yeah. Thank you.

RK: And we were there for 11 years, and it was a 15 minute ride to midtown, and a private drive when you got back there. I could leave in the morning, come back at lunch, go back into the City and do whatever you need, and we got into doing television commercials, because at one time we were about ready to go on a trip, to go on the road again, and this friend of ours, the same Rogers Brackett that introduced us to Alec Wilder, called up and said, "listen, I'm doing a jingle tomorrow for Halo Shampoo and we'd like to have you guys sing on it." And I said, "gee Rogers, we're leaving tomorrow to take this road trip."

JC: And our friend Don Payne wrote it too. He had written the jingle.

RK: And let's see, I said to Rogers I said, "no we can't do that, we're leaving tomorrow." And he said, "well I think it might be worth your while to just postpone leaving one day, it won't hurt too much." He said, "it'll probably mean quite a sum of money." And I said, "oh really?" He said, "oh yeah." So okay. We went in, we learned the thing, we recorded it, next day, Jackie and I we sang the thing and it was just like a vocalese.

JC: A very nice thing. It was a bossa nova.

MR: How did it go?

[Jackie and Roy scat]

JC: It was just like a simple little, but nice. And it was nothing tricky really.

RK: And we did that, next day we leave, we go, we're out in San Francisco and we're starting to get mail. Now here are these big fat envelopes coming in. And I — what is this? Oh yeah, advertising agency. Hey, there's probably some checks. We opened them up and we looked, nine hundred dollars. Next check, seven hundred, five hundred. Boom, boom, boom, boom. And I said what have we been doing all these years, it's more money than we're making for a month working these joints.

JC: You know in jazz you don't make all that much money, and this is like what, oh, we couldn't believe it. And for the few minutes that we were in the studio.

MR: Isn't that amazing?

RK: And we went back finally after months of traveling, we went back to New York and I started a production company just specifically to do television commercials. Now I had to attend a lot of meetings where they're arguing over whether it should be AND or BUT in the copy. And it's going back and forth.

JC: Yeah. Or some pronunciation of some silly little detail.

RK: And or but, no it's got to be but because that typifies — and I'm just sitting here like.

JC: Boring.

RK: Ho hum hum. And then they give you what they call a storyboard to work from, pictures, like cartoon pictures, and you've got to work from that, and you have so much time. Okay you see the film and you time everything up, and make it come out to 30 seconds or whatever it's going to be. They used to have minute commercials at the time. Then 30 seconds, and then taking ten second from those. And so I'd have to time everything out and get my stopwatch and I'd be sitting there working it out, adjust the tempo a little bit, yeah, a little faster, okay, boom, it came out right at the end you know.

JC: He was very good at it you know.

RK: So I submitted a lot of things. We finally did Cheerios. We did Plymouth Automobiles, we did Borden's Instant Coffee.

JC: We did a car thing for Plymouth Automobile with Red Norvo actually, he was on the thing.

RK: And a lot of these major accounts we got into, and we made a fortune doing it. Singing, of course I got the fee for arranging, I got the creative fee, I got the fee for leader, I got the fee for piano.

JC: Fi-fi-fo-fum.

RK: Fi-fi-fo-fum.

MR: Take those "fi's" right to the bank.

RK: And then I got very — I listened and I said wait a minute, there's an announcer's job comes out of this too. So at the end I would say, we'd finish the music, everything is

done, I'd say why don't you have me just read the copy so the announcer knows where it goes in this particular piece of music, so he knows when to come in, when to go out. "Good idea, that'll help us a lot." And so I'd give it "Cheerios," I'd give it like a big smile and like read that stuff.

JC: And he knew right where to put it because he's a musician.

RK: When to get out, when to finish, when to come in. And usually it took about three days, and they would call up and say, "would you be interested in doing the voiceover." And I'd say, "oh sure, that'd be wonderful." So — I loved it.

JC: Yeah it was great. Well it helped us to buy our house that we have now.

RK: Finally the owner of the house in Riverdale came back, he was in the Foreign Service, the son of Elie Nadelman, it was Jan Nadelman, he came back and we knew that it's time. Our tenure is up, we're not going to be here anymore. And we started house hunting. Well we looked in Nyack, we looked in Westchester, we looked here we looked there, we were so spoiled, having this huge property and trees, and view of the river and private drive. So now we can't find anything that we can afford.

JC: Of course the old furniture that we'd picked up that fit in the house.

RK: Friends of ours lived in Montclair and says, "when you're through house hunting, come by for dinner so you can relax and you don't have to be so depressed about not finding anything." So we're looking around Montclair, and we say gee, that looks nice, this is nice, we started to get the *New York Times* and picked it up on Sunday, looked at it, go out to Montclair, and get there, and finally we get there, and the ones we wanted were gone. We would get the *New York Times* on a Saturday and look, and circle things and call up the real estate agent, meet him there on a Sunday morning. Now we're in business. We looked here, there, this house, that house, that house. We walked into the house we now have, in 1973, the real estate agent was in front of me, I was behind her and Jackie was behind me. We walked in the door of this place and here's a great center hall, you step up and there's more hall and there's colonial center hall construction.

JC: Don't go through all that Roy.

RK: And Jackie is behind me and she pulls my coat and she says — [whispers] "This is it, this is it."

JC: I knew right away, I could see the quality of the house, and the way it was constructed. He did too.

RK: And we gave notice to our place there. They were happy to have us out and we moved in to this new place on May 1, 1973.

MR: And you are still there?

RK: Yes.

JC: We are still there. However, the only one unfortunate part of the story is that on May 5th our daughter was killed in an automobile accident.

MR: Oh, dear.

JC: So we moved in on the first, we were just still living out of suitcases, because we had a job that weekend in New York at a new club that opened, and we came home from the job Saturday night and on Sunday morning we got a call about 6:30 I guess it was, that our daughter was in an accident, get down to the hospital in Tom's River and so we did.

RK: It's an hour and a half's drive.

JC: We went down there.

RK: Prayers, prayers, prayers all the way down there.

JC: You think, never knowing what the outcome was or anything. We get there and walked in and the doctor says sit down, and you know we sat down, and he said we knew something bad was coming but we didn't think it was going to be that bad. But she was already dead. And we just fell apart. We just crumbled. And then we had to go back to Montclair to tell our daughter, she was waiting.

RK: Because our younger daughter was home.

JC: And so we went back, crying all the way. I'm surprised we even made it back because were just like blubbering. And we get back and we told her and that was a big shock and she went through terrible traumatic changes over it. And we all did. And gee for a couple of months we couldn't do anything. Our friends were feeding us.

RK: We couldn't listen to music. We couldn't play music. It was just too many memories in the music.

JC: We'd start crying immediately.

RK: So we scraped basement walls and dig in the mud in the garden and do this and do that, and all sorts of pedestrian chores.

JC: Trying to get the house together and whatever. It was hard though. We had to force ourselves. But we had to do it because we had the other girl.

RK: And our dear friend, Creed Taylor, who we'd recorded for many times, said, "listen, it's about time you guys start to do something." I said, "gee I don't know, Creed." Well he says, "I've got an opening for you at the Half Note."

JC: The Half Note, yeah.

RK: The Half Note in New York City on 56th street, it used to be there. And he said, "I'm going to get you a group and you're going to go into the Half Note and you're going to start performing again." Okay. So it was a date like a month away, and he got us Ron Carter on bass, Jack DeJohnette on drums, and Dave Friedman on vibes. And okay I'm writing parts and doing my parts, and not coming out with it, and put this together. We had sort of a piecemeal rehearsal. First we'd rehearse with Ron Carter, then Jack

DeJohnette would be able to come in, then Dave Friedman would come in, and finally opening night and we go in and these guys were such whizzes —

JC: They were so great.

RK: — that it was just uplifting. This wonderful music we were making together. So all of a sudden the joy of making music, making good music with a group is a great experience.

JC: It saved our lives, you know, it saved us. But you know one thing we did leave out, I just remembered that the year before this all happened in 1972 is when we made that album "Time and Love," which is the album we did for Creed Taylor, and that was such a wonderful time. We were going out to Fire Island in the summer. We were renting a house with our friend Bradley Cunningham, and we'd spent three months out there. And we hadn't been doing anything because we were doing the commercials. So at one point we said gee we've got to record something. We should get back in the studio and do something. And I don't remember how it came about — oh yeah we were going in and pitch it to Creed. We were going to go in and try and talk him into it.

RK: We'd done maybe four albums for him on Verve and so forth, and we were going to go into the city and just like talk it up — Creed we want to do another album, and like let's see what we can do, and so we walked in and we started talking, talking, talking, and he says, "that sounds like a good idea, let's do it."

JC: He didn't give us any opposition. We'd just started.

RK: And we've still got all this energy — let me tell you about — hey but I—

JC: He was for it right away. And then he got Don Sebesky on it, and of course Don Sebesky contributed such a tremendous amount, because he came up with a lot of the ideas and did all these big charts orchestrating, and of course there were a couple of Roy's things in there too but he orchestrated everything for a 70 piece orchestra. And it was just, I mean it was thrilling to do it.

MR: You had the cream of the — the best.

RK: The best players of New York.

MR: And I specifically remember hearing the title tune and just it was so beautiful, and all of a sudden when the Bach section came in, I said wow, that is brilliant.

RK: And the opening I think was where Jackie did the French horn part [humms].

JC: Was that, not "*Daphnis et Chloe*?"

MR: Oh no, that's from Stravinsky, isn't it?

JC: Yeah.

RK: No, no. Yes.

MR: It is Ravel? Or—

JC: Well there were several other symphonic—

RK: And I remember Jackie's nerves to do it.

JC: The first day we went into the studio, I had to sing that. And I hadn't been singing because we were doing commercials and we weren't working in a club then, that was before the Half Note and everything. And so I was warming up and trying to get my voice in shape, because we always do that before we do anything. But I went in the studio and I was so nervous, because I had to do this a capella. It was a [humms].

RK: "Afternoon of the Faun."

JC: Yes, "Afternoon of the Faun." And so I did it, and it worked out okay. And he was there conducting everything, and a lot of the string things of course were recorded separately and I had to just come in and fit them in, you know, with the earphones, and that's always such an unnatural situation. When you get in the studio, and you're thrown into these unnatural things where you're wearing earphones and the band isn't even there, and you're singing like alone in a booth, it's very hard to get into it.

MR: I can imagine.

RK: And there are a few places where it was just all conducted. And we couldn't coordinate — how long do you wait before you come in, before they come in, there would be spaces. And so we said, "Don, you've got to come help us, come into the studio." He said, "oh sure, yeah." And he said, "well now it's going to be like this" and he would come in and it'd be wrong.

JC: Even he couldn't really feel it.

RK: I said "Don, we've got to do this right." And he says "yeah but I can't find it either." So he said, "try it." And we put in little things like, gee if you touch yourself three times and then come in then it'll be all right.

JC: It was very tricky, very tricky. But we did enjoy it, and then I got to do "*Bachianas Brasileiras*," which was something I would never dream of attempting. But Don thought that I could do it, and thank God he let me try.

RK: And we did those charts, plus several others with the Syracuse Symphony, what year though, I can't remember.

JC: Well it had to be sometime right after that, so it had to be maybe '74, was it before Niki? No it had to be '72 sometime maybe.

RK: Later, no much later, much later.

MR: Was "A Simple Song" on that record also?

JC: Yeah.

MR: Was that a Bernstein?

RK: Yes. And Don Sebesky coupled it with Dave Brubeck's "Summer Song."

JC: No, no, you're thinking of another one. You're thinking of "Summertime" and "Summer Song." "Summertime" coupled with Dave Brubeck's "Summer Song," where we sing all

the voices, it sounds like a chorus, it's all us doing it. That was fun. So that was such a fun thing to do, because it was different.

MR: Now do you listen to yourself, your recordings?

JC: Not after we once do them.

RK: Very seldom. We'll hear them, we'll go to someone's house and they'll play something of ours—

JC: They think they're doing us a favor when we'd come over to a party or something, they're playing your records.

RK: In fact, that's what led us back to "East of Suez." Because we went into this place and they were playing "East of Suez." I said God, that sounds great, let's do that one again. So we put it in the right key and we did it again.

JC: But actually when you walk into somebody's house and they think that you'll enjoy it, you know, and it's really nice that they have them and that they play them, but all of a sudden you don't hear any conversation, you're listening to it.

MR: Why did I do that?

JC: Yeah, why did I do that, and there's always something that's a little funny that you could have done better, and you kind of re-live the day that you did it. It throws you right back there.

RK: I'm trying to think the other day, a few days ago, I said let's put that in again, oh, Cy Coleman's "My City."

JC: Yeah, it sounded darn good.

RK: And I haven't heard it in 15 years since we recorded it. And we never wanted to do it but I think we might go back to that one.

JC: Like last May we met this friend from Berlin, we'd never met him before, and Susanna McCorkle introduced us to him. And he's a D.J. and has his own radio show over there, and plays a lot of theater music and plays jazz because he personally likes jazz. And he's on all the time. And so he had been a fan of ours and had many of our records but had never met us, so we met him. And so now he said could I come out and do an interview with you. So he came out and we started talking about these different things. Like he wanted to do a whole Cy Coleman program. So we hadn't heard it since we did it really. And so I said well I think I have one, I'll find one for you, so I found him a tape, and then I thought gee I'd better listen to what the heck is on that thing, I don't remember all the songs we did. And we listened to it and said gee that sounds pretty good. Because when you listen to things that are older you forget, because you don't do all of them, sometimes you'll take one two from this album and one or two from another one and so on and so forth. You always like your current things the best because they're the freshest.

MR: Do you think there's anybody writing tunes today that are going to become standards?

JC: Well Johnny Mandel.

RK: Johnny Mandel is writing some gorgeous things.

JC: Dave Frishberg writes interesting things. Who else? There must be others. Well people like Gerry Mulligan have written classics but they're not songs with lyrics so I don't know. But there'll be standard classic jazz pieces, you know, just like his "Line for Lyons" and "Boplicity," and those things are gorgeous. They'll always sound good. And Gil Evans things, and who else, I don't know, Miles.

MR: Any of the show tunes perhaps?

JC: There are some. I mean some of Sondheim's things are very nice. We did a Sondheim album and we never thought we could do it because we always felt that they didn't lend themselves to jazz that well. And some of them don't as much as others. So we found some that we thought worked fairly well for us, and it turned out pretty good. We liked it.

MR: I wanted to read something you said. "A standard has chords that are familiar to anyone, yet interesting enough to the performer to encourage a serious approach."

RK: Yeah, that sounds right.

JC: Did you say that?

RK: Hey.

JC: Wow. That's my guy.

MR: A serious approach.

RK: Well you take the sheet music and some of it is great. Hey that's a good beginning. And then you do a little alteration, and do this and that, and make something that satisfies the inner self. It makes it interesting.

JC: And you know usually when we do a standard or something that people know, we try to honor it the way the composer wrote it, I mean pretty much so. You know you try to sing the melody the way — the right notes he wanted and the right chords. But then if it's a song that's really been used a lot and done by a lot of people, then we feel we can take more liberty. They've heard it that way. They've heard it that way a thousand times, and now we can start out and maybe do it a little differently, maybe change a note here or a chord there.

RK: And my greatest compliment in the last couple of years came from Johnny Mandel. He came in to hear us at the Jazz Bakery in Los Angeles. We had a very good rhythm section that came with us from San Francisco. It was popping, everything was great. And we did one of his songs called "The Shining Sea," which is a gorgeous melody. And I found — I explored ways to bring out more impressionistic sounds in it, just all kind of painting. And at the end he came out and we were talking and kicking stones and talking, and he said, "you know, you play like I think." And that's it. That's my best compliment in my whole life.

JC: The other one that I could relate is that Alec Wilder once said that we often break the rules but you don't mind it. And he's a stickler. He doesn't like it when you take too many liberties, but he says, "well Roy changes my chords but usually they're for the better."

RK: Yeah. God love him.

JC: He said some very nice things about us too.

MR: That's neat.

JC: And one time he said a thing about me that I'll never forget. He said "when she sings a song it stays sung." He said that on his radio show when I did it with [sounds like] Loonis McLeun, the NPR show you know, and that thrilled me that he would say that, because you know he doesn't mess around, he doesn't say nice things if he doesn't mean them.

MR: Why don't we take a pause for just a second. It's 4:30. I don't know if you're in a great hurry.

JC: Well we might have to come back later so we can live more of our live together. We're almost caught up here, well not quite.

RK: Really we're getting pretty close.

MR: We can wrap up, I don't know if there was anything particularly that you would like to get on tape. Because Roy was telling me that you're working on a documentary yourself, and if there's anything that you'd like to talk about, we could talk about it.

JC: We are right now, it's at a standstill because we're waiting to get some money. Because the people who are doing it, we have nothing to do with it that way.

RK: That's about it.

JC: This is somebody who we know who is a friend who respects and likes what we do, and so she's trying — they've done it so far on their own money, and it's been — we had one good session interview, but she wants to do a lot more things so they're trying to get a grant or something.

RK: Yeah, they're trying to get some money.

JC: They're trying to get some money from Herb Wong.

RK: I had mentioned this to Monk.

MR: Well you certainly have not been afraid to take some chances. Now I want to get the chronology right. The time you did "Time and Love." And then I remember liking that album and going out and getting another one, I'm not sure whether it came before it or —

JC: Probably after.

MR: And it had big stones on it? Like a desert kind of scene or something.

JC: "A Wilder Alias."

MR: That's the one. Now that was much different.

JC: It was so different.

MR: It was much more adventurous.

RK: There was rage in it.

JC: Well not all of it but some of it. That's right after our daughter died. And also the drummer that worked with us, Jimmy Molinari, he'd been with us a while, he got killed. Somebody killed him down in Manhattan somewhere. And we don't know the —

RK: It was two weeks after our daughter died, and Jimmy—

JC: It was a double whammy you know.

RK: It was something, I don't know what he got into, but he was just killed and thrown off a roof.

JC: We really don't know what happened. Nobody knows.

RK: So this album came out and it was that first tune—

JC: "A Wilder Alias."

RK: "A Wilder Alias." Because I said what Jimmy needed was A Wilder Alias to get away from whatever he was doing. Now a lot of people thought this was A. Wilder.

JC: Alec Wilder. And people who bought it thought that. Some of them.

RK: And here is some of this crazy music.

JC: It was kind of fierce music in there, you know, some of it, well one of them was, that particular song, "A Wilder Alias," and it had a lot of anger in it and stuff I think. But then there was other things that were softer. "Niki's Song" was her favorite song and we did that, the one about the beach, it originally was called "A Full Moon" and then we changed it to "Niki's Song." Creed said we should do it. I said that was Niki's favorite song, he said well why don't you call it that. So that was on and that was pleasant. But I think a lot of people were disappointed in it, I mean just the average person. A lot of musicians liked it. But then there were a lot of people that didn't like it because it wasn't typical Jackie and Roy, smiley, happy-go-lucky, clever.

MR: Yeah well that's not where you life was at right then, was it?

JC: That's right. Your music reflects your life you know. So I don't think that CD or album did very well.

RK: But Creed gave us full freedom, as always, just do it.

MR: You anticipated my next question. Have you ever been in a situation with a record company where they put significant pressure on you to do something because it's selling?

RK: Yes.

JC: Yeah, we've gotten pressure. Although we haven't succumbed to it often, but once we had to.

RK: Once we did a thing, it was Bob Thiele, who was with a record company, I don't remember.

JC: Was it Atlantic?

RK: Whatever. And he said, "listen, you guys have got to cross the line, you've got to do something that's very commercial. You've got to do a couple of Steve Allen songs" you've got to do this, you've got to do that.

JC: Broaden your audience.

RK: Broaden your audience. Okay. We said fine, all right, great. So among other things he gave us one song, he says, "you've got to do this." And it was a song written by Steve Allen called "Pa Take Me to the Circus" built on an old polka melody.

JC: That wasn't Steve Allen though, honey. Just some other tune that he thought would be a hit.

RK: [humms] In my home town, Czechoslovakian, it's called "barushka" polka. But this was something else. And we said okay. So we recorded these four things. And later we got home and we sat down and thought about what we did, and actually jumped up in the air in total horror and panic, thinking, what if it becomes popular.

JC: Because we'd have to do it.

RK: What would we do then?

JC: We'd have to do it all the time, oh what did we do?

RK: Oh what have we done?

JC: And that taught us a lesson. Don't ever do anything that you wouldn't be proud to do, you know, over and over.

MR: That's an excellent rule to remember.

JC: Yeah.

MR: Picture doing this on a gig.

JC: Now you've got to do it for the rest of your life.

RK: It's immediate hell.

MR: There's some more guidance that I guess came through for you. Did it get released?

RK: Yes.

JC: Yeah it was released, but I think it was — was it on vinyl or — I can't remember was it a 45?

RK: Throw it out of your mind.

JC: It was quite early.

RK: The song that was Steve Allen's was called "Oh Banana Split." That was kind of cute. [humms]

JC: But I mean we would never dream of singing it now, because I mean that was when we were young and you know you could get away with such cutsie pie stuff. But now I mean, I wouldn't dream of doing it now. But that's the way the world goes sometimes. Because he was trying to broaden our audience, and we said well okay, maybe this time we'll try it. But we'd been told stuff a lot of times, even Joe Glaser, who was our booker

at one time early on. We had a meeting with him, he says, "I don't know, you kids, you walk a line, you're not cabaret and you're not jazz, you're kind of walking the line there. Do one or the other." We said well this is who we are, this is what we do, this is what we like.

RK: These are the songs we like. This the music we love.

JC: And we were doing both because we could work both kinds of clubs. It made it better for us.

MR: Does that controversy still come up for you? Are you cabaret or jazz?

JC: Probably.

RK: Occasionally. Just like April 19, the Manhattan Association of Cabarets and Clubs will be honoring us with a Lifetime Achievement Award, at a special function they're having. So you know—

JC: And of course we got the 50 year anniversary celebration as part of the jazz festival last year.

RK: The JVC Jazz Festival.

JC: JVC Jazz Festival. And so that's another thing, that's a jazz thing, but you know, so be it. I don't care that much about awards, I just want to do what we want to do, and enjoy it, and we make our living doing it, and it's fun. If we weren't getting paid for it we'd still be doing it probably. But that's a bonus. And we get to travel all over, you know, that's one of the greatest things that we enjoy about it too, we've been to Europe, we've been to Australia, we've been to Japan, we've been to Brazil.

RK: Hawaii.

JC: And we get paid.

MR: And you're not going in a station wagon with column speakers on the top.

JC: That's right. We're enjoying seeing the world.

MR: You guys paid a lot of dues and it makes the good times that much better.

JC: Sure.

RK: You also learn a few things traveling. Don't drink the water. You know you to go San Francisco, and you change water, and all of a sudden you're feeling strange. You go down to Los Angeles, you drink that water, oh this is weird, it upsets your whole system.

JC: You're whole system, yeah.

RK: So the evils of the road.

JC: Well that and even food, you know eating out all the time. If you have to eat in restaurants all the time, it's not as good as what you probably would have if you were eating at home you know. It's all right to eat out occasionally but when you have to eat out every day, breakfast, and dinner, you have to be careful about your diet if you want to feel good. We tried to, sometimes you do the best you can do, which sometimes is

limited. So that's another thing that's important though when you're traveling, because otherwise your health — you know if you don't feel good, you can't work well and do well.

MR: If you were listening, if you had some time and you just wanted to listen to some stuff that you were influenced by when you were young in Chicago, or Milwaukee was it, what records would you pull out to listen to, to revisit your influences?

RK: Teddy Wilson piano; Earl "Fatha" Hines' big band; Woody Herman's Thundering Herd; Sonny Stitt, Charlie Parker, Dizzy Gillespie, Miles Davis.

JC: As we go, you go. I started out without even a record player listening to the radio. I'm talking about Jo Stafford and you know there were a few people, just hearing songs, good songs, and the singers were pretty good and I could learn them from the radio. And then also getting into more jazz things because I started working with bands around Milwaukee. You know playing stock arrangements most of the time, but I did get to meet a lot of musicians, and they'd say, "hey have you ever heard Billie Holiday — have you ever heard Peggy Lee — have you ever heard" this one, that one. And then I started listening to other people, and going to shows at the Riverside Theater in Milwaukee and I heard Dinah Washington with Lionel Hampton's band and I thought that was great, I loved her, and I saw Anita O'Day with Gene Krupa on the stage, and going to hear anything that was like that. And I was definitely drawn to jazz because when I'd hear a saxophone playing on the radio, oh, turn the sound up, what's that.

RK: I would listen to late night radio, I was supposed to be asleep but I would take a small radio under my covers, one of those little radios, and I would listen to Earl "Fatha" Hines broadcast from the Grand Terrace Ballroom in Chicago. And they would come on the air and you'd hear like [scats] and the brass is like [scats]. And then over all this you hear this voice come in and he says "Fatha Hines, Earl, Fatha Hines." [scats] And I'd listen and and oh God, that's so wonderful, that's what I want to do. And I was studying classical piano at the time. And the next morning I'd get up, go to the piano, and I discovered my piano didn't have those notes on it.

MR: It would take some time to find them, too. Yeah, that's great.

JC: I used to go into clubs in Milwaukee at times that I was really too young to be in these clubs. But the club owner would kind of overlook the fact that I was there. And I would sit in with different people. There was a group called Eddie Getz, and he was an alto player that Roy knew in the Army actually, and a very good player, and a good rhythm section, I mean as good as I thought they could be at that time.

RK: He was good.

JC: And they'd let me sit in. I guess they thought I wasn't too bad or they wouldn't have asked me to come in. They'd always want me to come up. I'd sing "The Man I Love" and

I don't know what all, the funny songs you know, can't remember even the rest. That was before I sang "Happiness is a Thing Called Joe" after I heard Frances Wayne sing it. But you know when people say who were your influences, everything you hear is your influence you know? I mean there were so many singers, how can you nail it down to one or two people? As I went along I loved Ella, I loved Billie Holiday of course, who else, Peggy Lee I mentioned.

RK: And your good buddy Sarah Vaughan.

JC: Oh and Sarah Vaughan was a very big influence on me in the early, when I was first working with Roy. Because she was very hot then. She was just coming into prominence. And Dave Garroway is the one who dubbed her "The Divine One." And he would talk about her all the time and play her records, and I said yeah, she's great. I sounded like her for a while because sometimes inadvertently people you like, it rubs off on you you know. You're not trying to copy them really, but it's just a period of development you know, that you're learning as you go.

MR: Yes. It's a sincere form of flattery too.

JC: Yeah. And then at one point I finally got smart enough to say hey wait a minute, you don't want to sound like somebody else, you want to have your own sound, so — maybe somebody suggested that to me, I don't remember. But I did realize that I had to — so I started just singing pure and straight ahead, and not too tricky. And the thing that I believe in is that you should serve the song, rather than have the song serve you. So too much stylistic stuff doesn't make it for me. I mean Sarah, I liked Sarah the best in her early days, the early records. Because she even got almost too stylistic, but she was so wonderful, you couldn't help but love her.

RK: That vocalisma.

JC: She had such a marvelous instrument and she had such facility with it, and she always did good music and had good groups, so I mean she's a-okay, and always was. But I liked her early stuff, the way she sang, you know, simpler.

RK: I just remembered that last night, Marian McPartland took us, we were sitting backstage talking, and she took us back to Jump Town, where met and started playing. She said that she and Jimmy McPartland were playing in Chicago.

JC: At the Brass Rail.

RK: At the Brass Rail, and they would rush out after their final set to hear us at Jump Town, night after night after night. And we never knew it.

JC: We never knew it. Yeah that was funny.

MR: And just last night she related that.

JC: Because I did know that they used to come and hear us when we were playing somewhere downtown too, and that was later, with Ventura.

RK: That was with Charlie Ventura.

JC: But I didn't know that they had come to the other place.

MR: What's coming up in the near future for you?

RK: We just got back from Florida, we did a concert down there for the Gold Coast Jazz Society, and we didn't know what to expect because we haven't been performing in Florida, and it just happened.

JC: I think we only did one job down there, at a club called Bubba's.

RK: At any rate, we went down and we rehearsed with Don Payne the bass player who we met in Riverdale.

JC: Our friend's house we used.

RK: And then a guy who's been with us recording and on tour, Steve Bagley the drummer. And so it was alumni. We rehearsed them and did the concert and it turned out to be wonderful, it was just perfect.

JC: It was in a beautiful little theater, just the right size.

RK: Gorgeous Steinway piano. It played itself, all I had to do was sit there and look. And we did that and then we hung out in Naples, Florida with some of our friends for about five days vacationing. Came home. Opened up the suitcases, emptied them, put them away, and all of a sudden we get a call from John Schriber, he said, "I know it's kind of sudden, but could you guys appear on Marian McPartland's 80th birthday on Saturday?" This was Thursday.

JC: Thursday night.

RK: And we said, yeah, sure, why not? We're here. Okay. And he says, "oh thank you, you saved our lives, because Joe Williams got sick and he's not going to be able to make it." So that was it. And then Jackie said why not, for Marian's 80th birthday, let's sing that song of hers that she wrote with Peggy Lee. What's it called?

JC: "In the Days of Our Love," which is pretty.

RK: So I went looking through music and then I just had to go back 15 years or whatever, two years ago we did it I think.

JC: Well we did it a couple of years ago, once.

RK: To find it, to see what key or what the melody is or what the lyrics are. And so Friday Jackie's going back and learning this song, that she's going to do Saturday, with Marian.

JC: Yeah. And I'm not used to working with other pianists very often, because I don't get to do it that much. You know I've done it a few times but not often. And so we ran through it once in the theater, you know, when we came in for the sound check. And her chords sounded so totally different. And it was an odd piece.

RK: Only in a few places. Oh God, she played some beautiful things.

JC: Oh she played beautiful things, yeah. But it did sound different to me, and I don't know, it was another key for her too, because she didn't write it in that key. But she's amazing.

RK: She's brilliant.

JC: She is brilliant that way. She can do any key.

RK: Bamm just like that she got it.

JC: I mean she's just great. So we did it last night, and I was like a little nervous on it, and I kind of clenched up there a couple of times. But I got through it, and after I came back to the release after she played a half a chorus, then I got it better, because I had been through it once and, oh yeah, now I remember what it is. That was through though and being a broadcast, you know, a live broadcast, made me feel pressured about it. I probably wouldn't have been nervous but I was nervous because of that.

RK: And for me it was a great pleasure working with Grady Tate on drums.

JC: And Christian McBride.

RK: And I really loved Christian's playing. And he's such a big, warm guy, like he just gives you hugs and says, "yeah, it was good playing with you again." And with Grady, after we finished, I'm going to tell you this and you can cut it if you like, I went over to him, we went down to the dressing room and I put my arm around him and says, "Grady, it was just wonderful, because playing with you is really a comfort." And he says "yeah, like a jock strap."

JC: We know him pretty well because he does the Jazz Nativity with us every year. We've been doing that thing for eight, nine years. And this year he sings the opening song. He's a wonderful singer, as you know. And then of course we see him every year at that, and so we're always in the same dressing room. Everybody's in the one dressing room, and there's a lot of jokes, and that's one of the things we enjoy about doing that is because we get to hang out with the musicians every year.

MR: Well I want to thank you so much for making it into the city today because I've been looking forward to talking to you, and I want to thank you for your marvelous career.

JC: Oh thank you.

MR: And all the records you've recorded.

JC: Great, great.

RK: It's been a grand life and as I said before, I know we've had some angelic guidance. Just certain things have come up that you can't believe, how come?

JC: Yeah, we've been very fortunate. We try to honor the music and do the best we can when we're working, and we just love doing it. So we feel that we're just so fortunate and so lucky. You know we're going to do it as long as we can. Very often people say, "do you guys ever think about retiring?" We say why would we? You know, unless we can't do it anymore. If we don't sound good enough, if we don't think we sound good enough to go

out and do it we'll stop doing it. But if we can make it and keep making it good enough, we will.

RK: Father John, a priest from Boston, said to us, he said, "you two are running your own ministry."

JC: That was nice. I'll buy that dream.

MR: All right. Well I hope you enjoy the rest of your evening.

JC: Thank you. We're going over to hear another favorite, Blossom Dearie. Yeah she's great. We're going to hear her tonight. Thank you very much for inviting us.

RK: Thank you, Monk.

JC: You came well — well people spoke of you before we came here and they said oh you'll love him, you'll like him. Yeah, yeah.

MR: That's nice to hear.

JC: And you are very comfortable to talk to.

MR: Appreciate that.

JC: Enjoyed it.

MR: That's 'cause I'm talking to people who do what I love, and do it well.

JC: Great, thanks.

RK: And thank you, Tim. All right. And God bless us all.

MR: Nothing can be said after that.

RK: 'Twas the best of times, 'twas the worst of times. Well this is the best.